FINAL WHISTLE

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Self-written sample screenplay for Panelwise.
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FADE IN:

EXT. DUSTY SOCCER FIELD - DAY

A sand pitch with bent goalposts and no nets. A crowd lines the touchlines on car bonnets and plastic chairs.

The scoreboard is a blackboard: LIONESSES 1 - EAGLES 1.

A girls' team in faded green kit, the LIONESSES, stands in a huddle. Their captain, PALESA (15), wears the armband over a bandaged wrist.

COACH DLAMINI (40s), tracksuit, whistle, bucket hat, kneels in the middle of the huddle.

COACH DLAMINI
Five minutes. They are tired. You are tired. The difference is you want it more.

PALESA
And if they want it more too?

COACH DLAMINI
Then run faster than your wanting.

EXT. DUSTY SOCCER FIELD - MOMENTS LATER

The match. Dust kicks up. The Eagles' STRIKER, in red, breaks through and shoots.

The Lionesses' goalkeeper, LINDI (14), small, with oversized gloves, dives. The ball smacks into her chest. She holds on.

CROWD
Lindi! Lindi! Lindi!

Lindi rolls the ball out to Palesa.

EXT. DUSTY SOCCER FIELD - CONTINUOUS

Palesa dribbles up the left wing. A red defender slides in. Palesa hops over the tackle, but lands on her bad wrist.

She cries out. The ball rolls away.

The REFEREE (50s), striped shirt, blows his whistle.

REFEREE
Free kick! Green!

SMASH CUT TO:

EXT. DUSTY SOCCER FIELD - TOUCHLINE - CONTINUOUS

Coach Dlamini wraps fresh tape around Palesa's wrist. Palesa grits her teeth.

COACH DLAMINI
You can come off. Nobody will say anything.

PALESA
I will say something.

COACH DLAMINI
Then who takes the kick?

Palesa looks across the pitch. Lindi stands alone in her goalmouth, bouncing on her toes.

PALESA
Lindi.

COACH DLAMINI
The goalkeeper?

PALESA
She kicks it further than anyone. She just never gets to.

CUT TO:

EXT. DUSTY SOCCER FIELD - CONTINUOUS

Lindi jogs the whole length of the pitch in her big gloves. The crowd murmurs. The Eagles' players laugh and point.

She places the ball. She takes four steps back. She pulls off her gloves and hands them to Palesa.

The Eagles build a wall. Their goalkeeper crouches.

The whistle.

Lindi runs, and strikes the ball with everything she has. It rises over the wall, dips, and crashes in off the crossbar.

CROWD
GOAL!

The Lionesses pile on top of Lindi. Palesa holds up the gloves, laughing.

EXT. DUSTY SOCCER FIELD - SUNSET

The crowd has gone. The blackboard now reads LIONESSES 2 - EAGLES 1.

Lindi sits alone on the touchline wearing her gloves, a small dented TROPHY between her feet. Palesa sits down next to her.

PALESA
Next season you're playing striker.

LINDI
Who goes in goal?

PALESA
(holding up her taped wrist)
Me. I'm better with my feet than my hands anyway.

They laugh. The sun goes down behind the bent goalposts.

FADE OUT.